



COMM 1131 Exam 3 Study Guide

Sex, Relationships, and Communication (Northeastern University)



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Chapter 8: Love and attachment

● Be able to explain Marston's and Hecht's Love Ways.

1. They suggest that people recognize that their partner's preferred communication may be different from their own.
 - ex. if Brian expresses love through physical touch and likes to hug and hold hands in public, he should not necessarily expect Gabriela to want the same

Love is **experienced** in a variety of ways and **communicated** to others in a variety of ways
Focuses on physiological and behavioral responses to love.

2. People should be careful not to overvalue particular elements of their own way of communicating loving
ex. Gabriela preferring to express love through time and activities and Brian starts to develop sports interest, or argue about old movies to watch

→ In return, Gabriela should recognize that other aspects of their relationship may still reflect their love for one another

3. Focusing on various ways to love each other instead of a 'ultimatum-like' statements

Should refrain from "If you really loved me, you'd give me more space"
"If you really loved me, you'd tell me more often..."

A dyad should bring different ideologies and expectations about love to the relationship
The key is to appreciate what each partner brings to the table, rather than wishing that the table was set in a different way

● How do the Love Ways relate to communication?

Allows the dyad to communicate their feelings towards each other in various ways.

Physiological changes occur when in love

- Most common response: people reported feeling more energetic and emotionally intense

Saying 'I love you' to communicate love

- Do we need to know the types of love? (Collaborative, active, intuitive, etc).

- Be able to thoroughly explain Attachment Theory for children and adults.

Children first learn to develop attachments through communication with caregivers.
As children grow, they develop a sense of independence that is rooted in security.

Adulthood: Security in adulthood is based on being self-sufficient when necessary
Having the ability to provide care and support for another adult in a love relationship that functions as a partnership.

- Why are attachment styles important?

They involve communication based behaviors.
Communication is one of the key causes of attachment styles

People's communication with others leads them to think about themselves and others in ways that lead them to develop particular attachment styles.
Communication is also a result of one's attachment style

- How are they reinforced?

Self-disclosure, emotional expression, caregiving, conflict behavior, nonverbal behaviors

- What working models do they involve?

Positive Self-Model

- The degree to which a child develops an internalized sense of self-worth that is not dependent on external validation

Are deemed to view themselves as self-sufficient, secure, and lovable

Working Model of Others

- the degree to which a child expects others to be supportive and accepting

- What role do caregivers have in attachment?

1. Sensitivity to signals

Detecting and interpreting the infant's signal correctly (ex. crying, laughing, facial expressions)
appropriately responding in a timely manner

2. Physical and psychological availability

Physically close

Emotionally open and available

3. Acceptance of the infant's needs

● How do attachment styles change?

1. *Significant life/relationship events*

ex. a particular bitter divorce may prompt a change in attachment style (i.e. from secure to dismissive)

Dismissive

- people with a dismissive attachment style are self-sufficient to the point of pushing others away
- People with a dismissive attachment style are not interested in relationships
- Do not want to provide (to self and others) that they can cope with life on their own
- Dislike relying on others
- Prioritize personal goals and activities over relationships; often think that relationships 'hold them back; from achieving their goals
- People with a dismissive attachment style use low levels of relational maintenance disclosure and emotional expression

2. *The partner's attachment style*

Ex. a secure partner may help a fearful partner become more secure

Secure - likely to engage in compromise and problem-solving during conflict

Are likely skilled communicators

- Disclosures, expression of emotions, etc.

3. *Variability across relationship types*

You may be securely attached in your close friendships, but preoccupied in your romantic relationships

Chapter 9: Communicating Sexually

● Be able to describe the research about hookups we discussed in lecture.

Motivated by sexual desire, sexual experimentation, physical pleasure, alcohol or drug use

Most research indicates that alcohol use is involved in the majority of hook ups

If hookups are consensual, most research suggest they do not lead to negative long-term psychological consequences

Women report fewer positive feelings about hooking up than men

Hook ups do not always involve intercourse

College students today are not more sexually active than college students in the past

Today's students are more likely to report having had sex with a friend

● What are the orientations toward sex?

1. Procreational (parents)

Producing offspring is the primary purpose of sexual intercourse

- the position taken by most major religions
- associated with traditional, conservative cultural values

2. Recreational (rec track, running, excitement)

People who view sex as a primary source of fun, escape, excitement, or pleasure.

- Sexual liberal view
- Holding that sex is appropriate between consenting adults regardless of their relationships

3. Relational (balance)

that sexual intercourse is a way of expressing love and affection - intimacy - and developing greater relational intimacy

- equated with moderate sexual values,
- is widespread in the US
- People with this orientation disapprove of casual sex but usually approve of premarital sex in the context of a committed or loving relationship.

● How do people time sex in their relationships?

Rapid involvement (7% of US heterosexual couples)

- Sex on the first date
- Strong endorsement of sex as recreational

Gradual Involvement (32% of US heterosexual couples)

- Sexual involvement moves through stages
- Sex occurs before exclusivity is established

- Recreational/relational orientation towards sex

Delayed Involvement (44 % of US heterosexual couples)

- Sex occurs only after exclusivity is established
- Strong endorsement of relation orientation

Low Involvement (17% of US heterosexual couples)

- Waiting until marriage or engagement

Relational/procreational orientation

● How are communication, sexual satisfaction, and relational satisfaction interconnected?

Couples with high levels of sexual satisfaction also report high levels of love, connection, excitement, and relational satisfaction

Direct, verbal, partner-to-partner instrumental communication also increases relational satisfaction

- Instrumental communication = messages aimed at accomplishing a task

Indirect communication about sex is not effective in increasing relational satisfaction

● Flirting – why do people flirt?

Convey their interest and attraction, especially when they are in the early stages of a relationship

- 1) Amusement, to have fun
- 2) To boost self-esteem
- 3) To gauge another's romantic interest
- 4) To reinforce a relationship
- 5) To find a mate

● What are the flirting styles?

1. Physical (Angel)

Based on communicating sexual and romantic interest,

Includes more references to physical appearance as well as more touching

Are highly comfortable and believe they are good at showing their sexual interest to others

2. Polite (Peace)

Revolves around caution and the idea that expression of sexual interest in inappropriate.

May appear reserved

Desire long-term relationships

3. Playful (AI)

Flirting can be fun, does not necessarily need to be tied to starting a relationship with someone

May flirt with people who are not really interested in

Flirt to feel amusement and enhance self-esteem

4. Sincere (Me)

Based on creating an emotional bond

Perceived as being honest

Want to feel an emotional connection to someone ; are motivated to get to know them better

5. Traditional (Mom)

Subscribe to traditional gender-specific roles

- men make the first move, approach women, lead interaction, and make request for future engagement

Heterosexual standpoint

When does flirting become harassment?

Inappropriate sexual comments, behaviors, or requests are made.

If someone uses a Physical style of flirting and they start grabbing someone's breasts or buttocks - that's harassment

Coercive tactics

Or if one is trying to use the sincere style of flirting and asks about a coworker's love life, but the receiver is not interested.

● How do people initiate dating and sex?

1. Hunting and indirectness

2. **Expressions of closeness**
3. **Use of logic and reasoning**
4. **Pressure and manipulation**
5. **Use of anti-social acts**

● Safer sex communication – what are barriers?

1. The ‘truth bias’

Individuals tend to assume that people they like are telling them the truth

2. Lack of condom use - not wanting to be seen as promiscuous

limiting spontaneity and reduce sensation

3. Not wanting to ‘ruin the moment’
4. Not wanting to convey distrust or hurt a partner’s feelings

● What does safer sex communication include?

1. Practicing abstinence
2. Practice secondary abstinence
3. Avoid high-risk sex
4. Using condoms
5. Getting tested
6. Limit your partners
7. Really know your partners
8. Avoid intoxication
9. Be honest

Chapter 10: Maintaining relationships

● Be able to explain Dr. Helen Fisher’s research on the brain and relationship maintenance.

How do you sustain feelings of romantic love in long-term relationships?

1. Maintain sex drive

Sex elevates levels of oxytocin and dopamine

These brain chemicals reinforce feelings of boundedness and positivity

2. Engage in novel activities

An interested brain is a happy brain

3. Maintain attachment to partner

Verbally and non-verbally

- Verbal: "I love you"
- Non-verbal: Holding hands, hugging, etc.

What are long-term couples good at, according to brain research?

- 1. Communicating empathy for the partner

Empathy = the capacity to understand or feel what another person is experiencing within their frame of references

- Being able to place yourself in another's position

2. Controlling own emotions (Dad)

- Especially negative emotions
- Especially during conflict

3. Engaging in positive illusions

- positive illusion = emphasizing a partner's positive qualities while simultaneously downplaying their negative qualities

● Be able to explain and identify pro-social maintenance behaviors.

1. Positivity

2. Openness

3. Assurances

4. Social networking

5. Task sharing

- Couples who use high levels of these 5 prosocial maintenance behaviors tend to have overlapping identities
- Have relationships characterized by high levels of satisfaction, commitment, liking, and love

● Be able to explain and identify anti-social maintenance behaviors.

Avoidance - avoiding talking about how attracted you are to a friend

distancing yourself from a friend who has a crush on you

refraining from arguing with your partner on a particular topic (afraid of it causing damage to relationship)

Jealousy induction (ultimatums)

- jealousy might spark feelings of love and possessiveness, make a partner more likely to stay in a relationship

Spying

Infidelity

Destructive conflict (coercion, manipulation)

Are anti-social maintenance behaviors bad for relationships?

Not always, it can save relationships and keep them platonic

Can save negative face

Acts like avoidance, no flirting, and talking about others can be effective

- can lead to relational satisfaction

● From interdependence theory, what are rewards, costs, and outcomes?

Interdependence theory involves human relationships that have an exchange of rewards and costs

- Rewards = exchanged resources that are pleasurable and gratifying
- Costs = exchanged resources that result in a loss of punishment

What are comparison levels and comparison levels for alternatives?

1. Comparison level - predicts satisfaction

What kind of outcomes are we expecting from the relationship?

Likely based in part on your past relationships

- How do outcomes compare to our expectations?

'Just ok' positive outcomes vs. 'really good' positive outcomes

If outcomes exceed comparison level expectation = satisfaction

2. Comparison level of alternatives - predicts dependence on relationships

Perception of outcomes if you were to leave the relationship and move to the best alternative situation you think is suitable for you

- Could I do better with someone else?
- Would I be happier if I was single?

What else influences outcomes?

Investments:

- What would you lose if the relationship were to end? How important are these investments to you?

Self-esteem

- impact how people think about comparison for alternatives

Access to information

- How much do you really know about comparison for alternatives?

What are the four types of relationships?

1. Happy, stable relationship

Current outcomes exceed comparison level of alternatives and comparison

2. An unhappy, stable relationships

Current outcomes are lower than comparison level but higher than comparison level for alternatives

3. A happy, unstable relationship

Current outcomes are above comparison level but below comparison level for alternatives

4. An unhappy, unstable relationship

Current outcomes are lower than comparison level and comparison level for alternatives

● Be able to explain Love Languages and their role in relationship maintenance.

Some people may prize some prosocial maintenance behaviors over others

Depending on the person, some prosocial maintenance behaviors are more meaningful than others

In the maintenance stages of relationships, this can become important for relationship satisfaction

● What is the difference between strategic maintenance and routine maintenance?

Strategic

- intentionally designed to maintain a relationship

Doing something special for your partner on their birthday

Doing something for your partner to apologize after a fight

Routine

- are used without the express purpose of maintaining a relationship
- help couples preserve their bonds with one another

Task sharing

- e.g. preparing everyday meals together

Positivity

- e.g. expressing happiness when your partner gets home from school or work

● What are issues associated with maintenance in long distance relationships?

Lack of face-face communication

Less maintenance behaviors (openness, assurances, joint activities)

- Be able to explain Equity Theory.

Focuses on determining whether the distribution of resources in a relationship is fair to both relational partners

- Predicts that people are most satisfied with a relationship when the ratio between benefits and contributions is similar for both partners

- What does Equity Theory tell us about satisfying relationships?

People in satisfying relationships develop rules for distributing resources fairly

Chapter 11: Conflict

- Be able to explain the definition of “conflict,” frequency of conflict, and common conflict issues

- Conflict: Disagreement between two interdependent people who perceive that they have incompatible goals

Conflict does not always involve yelling or aggression

- Frequency of conflict in romantic relationships:

Most romantic couples have between 1 and 3 small disagreements per week, and 1 or 2 serious disagreements per month

- Some level of conflict is normal and healthy in close relationships

A totally lack of conflict suggests that one partner is being too passive

Common Conflict Issues:

1. Household chores
2. Money

Sharing assets and revenues...Joint bank accounts...Prenuptial agreement

3. Jealousy
4. Sex
5. Children

How to raise kids, how many do ‘we’ want?

- Be able to describe Gottman’s couple types.

1. *Validating couples*

- Put a great deal of emphasis on supporting and understanding their partner’s point of view

Empathetic

Tend to agree on issues such as sex, money, religion, and children

When disagreements occur, they work out compromises

Disagreements are calm and measured

- No shouting
- No 'below the belt' comments

2. Volatile couples

Couple is comfortable with disagreement and lack of harmony

Communication style is emotionally expressive

Enjoy debate

Disagreements are settled through argument and discussion

Conflict tends to be productive and energizes the relationship

Communication is usually characterized by laughter, shared amusement, and humor

3. Conflict avoidant couples

- Do not like conflict
- Not emotionally expressive
- Emphasize common ground
- Partner placate and please each other rather than meet their own needs
- Often walk away from arguments
- Achieve a clear balance between independence and interdependence

This couple type is most likely to have separate friends and interests

- But also are usually very connected when they engage in mutual interests

4. Hostile/engaged couples

- Argue frequently and usually in an unproductive way
- Both partners are highly defensive
- Frequent use of insults, sarcasm, and personal criticism

Hostile couples are in your face arguing

Hostile couples do not last a very long time

5. Hostile/disengaged couples

- Argue frequently and usually in an unproductive way
- During conflict, unable or unwilling to see the other person's perspective
- Partners do not listen to one another
- Emotional disengagement from the partner and the relationship

Uses passive aggression to 'needle' the partner

● Which couple types tend to have satisfying relationships?

Validating couples, volatile couples, conflict avoidant couples

● What are the conflict styles?

BASED ON 2 DIMENSIONS

● Degree of directness

The extent to which individuals directly talk about issues, express their opinions, and pursue their goals

● Degree of cooperativeness

The extent to which individuals consider the needs and perspectives of their partner

STYLES

1. *Competitive fighting*

Direct, aggressive, hostile, and uncooperative

Competing to defeat the partner/win the argument

Win-lose orientation (I win, you lose)

- “win” is only temporary

Usually associated with poor communication competence and relational dissatisfaction

➤ Specific tactics include:

personal criticism

blaming or accusations

hostile questioning and teasing

Presumptive attribution

demands and threats

2. *Compromising*

Direct, moderately cooperative

Part-win, part lose orientation

- Each partner gives up something

Quality of compromise varies based on how mutually acceptable the outcome is

- Is the compromise fair to all parties?

➤ Specific tactics include:

taking the middle ground

alternating

appealing to fairness

3. *Collaborating*

Direct and cooperative

Win-win orientation

- Creative problem solving to satisfy both partner's needs

Solution-oriented

Most effective

- Specific tactics include:

Inquiring about the partner's feelings

Communicating support and empathy

Accepting responsibility

Emphasizing commonalities

Initiating problem-solving and brainstorming

4. *Indirect fighting*

Indirect, uncooperative, and hostile

Passive aggressive strategies

Focus on dismissing the partner's position and shutting down conversation in an effort to lose the argument

- Specific tactics include:

ignoring the partner or giving the silent treatment

cold or dirty looks

rolling one's eyes

sarcasm and contemptuous looks

5. Avoiding

Indirect, neutral cooperation

Sometimes leads to a lose-lose situation with issues left unresolved

However, in some cases, avoiding is beneficial

- preferable to aggression
- Choosing to avoid vs. feeling silenced
- Topical: 'agree to disagree'

- Specific tactics include:

denying the conflict exists

being indirect and evasive about the conflict

changing topics

6. Yielding

Cooperative, indirect

Lose-win orientation (I lose, you win)

Problematic if one person always gives in (the chilling effect)

Beneficial if the conflict issue is more important to one partner than the other

➤ Specific tactics include:

appeasement (giving in)

smoothing over differences

passive acceptance of alternative positions

● Be able to explain Negative reciprocity.

“Aggression creates more aggression”

- Once one person uses competitive or indirect fighting, the other person is likely to suit.

3 problems related to negative reciprocity

1 and 2. Gunnysacking and kitchen-sinking

Gunnysacking = storing up past grievances and dumping them (all at once) on a partner during a conflict

Kitchen-sinking = rehashing old arguments during a conflict

Because multiple attacks are involved, partners feel defensive and overwhelmed

3. Bringing other people into the conflict

- Promotes feelings defensiveness, which make problem resolution very difficult
- Mentioning negative things other people have said about the partner
- Saying negative things about the partner's friends or family
- Comparing partner to former partners

● Be able to explain the demand-withdraw pattern and its manifestations.

One person wants to engage in conflict or makes demands on a partner and the other wants to avoid it

- The person in the demanding position is likely to be in a less powerful position (relative to the partner)

Demander uses highly charged emotional requests, criticism, complains

Withdrawer uses defensiveness and passive inaction

4 Manifestations of the Demand-Withdraw pattern

1. Discuss/exit

One partner seeks discussion of an issue; the other partner exits physically or communicatively

2. Perfunctory response

One partner asks a series of questions; the other gives inauthentic responses

- Partner A: "Will you take care of the cat's box?"
- Partner B: "Yes."
- Partner A: "When will you do it?"
- Partner B: "Later."
- Partner A: "What does that mean?"
- Partner B: "I don't know, later."
- Partner A: "I need you to tell me."
- Partner B: "Ok."

3. Complain/deny

One partner complains about an issue; the other partner denies the legitimacy of the issues

- Partner A: "Did you take care of the cat's box like you said you would?"
- Partner B: "I don't know why you keep bringing this up. It's not a big deal."

4. Criticize/Defend

Partner A: "You are being disrespectful about the cat's box"

Partner B: "I'm not being disrespectful —you are, baby bringing it up all the time"

● Be able to explain the problem of punctuation.

People in a conflict can't agree on the cause of their conflict

Each partner blames the other for the conflict

This makes conflict resolution very difficult

Partner A: "I have to nag you all the time because you always withdraw"

Partner B: "I have to withdraw because you are always nagging me"

- Notice that both partners blame the other for their behavior

● What is the Cascade Model (Four Horsemen of the Apocalypse) and why is it important?

Model for understanding how conflict can negatively impact relationships (causes of divorce)

Gottman's research suggests that within the first three minutes of an interaction, the presence of these forms of communication can predict divorce with an accuracy rate of over 90%

❖ Criticism

Complain + negative words about partners character or personality

- “Why are you so selfish? I always have to take care of the cat’s litter box. You really just don’t care”

❖ Defensiveness

Occurs when people feel the need to protect themselves from personal attacks

Partner A : “Did you text Laura and Steve to let them know that we’re not coming tonight, like

you promised this morning?”

◦ Partner B: “I was too busy today! As a matter of fact you know just how busy my schedule was.

Why didn’t you just do it? Why do I have to do everything?”

❖ Contempt/disgust

With a partner as a ‘whole person’

Fueled by long-standing problems in a relationships

Suggests superiority “I’m better than you”

- Hostile humor, name calling, mockery, insult, sarcasm, eye rolling, ‘you’re crazy’, ‘you can’t do anything right’

❖ Stonewalling

Occurs after chronic criticism, contempt, and defensiveness

- Partners ‘turn to stone’ - they disengage, stop communicating, and see **continued interactions as futile**

● What is Accommodation?

In order for people to be able to successfully substitution the antidotes for the four horsemen of the apocalypse, they need to be able to engage in accommodation

1. People have a tendency to retaliate or withdraw when the partner engages in negative behavior, demand leads to withdrawal and withdrawals leads to demand, and criticism and contempt to lead to defensiveness and eventually stonewalling
2. Accommodation occurs when people are able to overcome these initial tendencies and agree in cooperative rather than uncooperative communication to maintain their relationships
3. Couples in satisfying, committed relationships more often use accommodation than couples in uncommitted or dissatisfying relationships

There are many ways to accommodate a partner's negative behavior, including refraining from reacting angrily, using appropriate humor, or showing positive affect.

● What is emotional flooding?

Occurs when people become 'surprised, overwhelmed, and disorganized' by their partners 'expressions or negative emotions'

Often happens when negative emotions become so intense that people automatically resort to 'fight-or-flight response'

- people usually experience high levels of physiological arousal - increased heart rate and high blood pressure -
- having difficulty processing new information, rely on stereotype thoughts and behaviors
- respond with aggression, or withdrawal

How should people productively deal with it?

When feeling angry, go to a different room and write a letter to one another. After some time has passed, read the letter to yourself, and decide to share with the other.

- Sometimes, it is not necessary to share, because half of the stuff that was written wasn't actually meant in real-time. It's just a 'heat of the moment' situation.

● Be able to describe what happens in the brain during periods of chronic stress.

Prompts the release of cortisol (stress hormone), epinephrine, norepinephrine, from the adrenal glands

Coping with stress

- 1. Change relationship
- 2. Terminate relationship
- 3. Exercise
- 4. Mediation

What are the health impacts of chronic stress?

- Hypertension
- Cholesterol plaque build up
- IBS (Irritable Bowel Syndrome)
- Weight gain

- Weakened immune system

- What does Attribution Theory tell us about the conflict styles that people will use?

A perceptual process of assigning reasons or causes to another's behavior

Three Specific Types of Attributions:

What kinds of attributions do people make?

1. Personal vs. Situational

Is the cause of this conflict a personality flaw (personal) or is the cause of the conflict due to the circumstances we are in and external factors? (situational)

EX. Doug might be upset because Mary ran out and got his birthday present at the last minute, causing them to be late for their dinner reservation. He could attribute Mary's behavior to personality factors (Mary is forgetful and disorganized) or to situational factors (Mary has been especially busy with work and has had to drive Amanda to the hospital every day after work).

2. Unstable vs. stable

Is the behavior that is making me upset atypical (unstable) or typical (stable)

3. Global vs. Specific

Is the behavior that is making me mad apparent elsewhere (global) or does it apply to this particular situation (specific)?

- The more global a cause is, the greater number of behaviors and situations it applies to

- What are the research-backed suggestions for engaging in productive conflict?

1. Be aware of confirmation bias

Confirmation bias = when you gather evidence that reinforces your beliefs and disregard evidence that challenges your beliefs

2. Think about attributions

We have a tendency to base our own mistakes on a particular situation, but we often base our partner's mistakes on a character deficiency

- "If I'm treating you poorly, it's because I had a bad day. If you're treating me poorly, it's because you're bad at relationships"